Donor Coalition Evolution and Congressional Career Trajectory

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Abstract

Members of Congress make career decisions under uncertainty. Before a statewide election has revealed their electoral support beyond their district, House members must assess whether the financial and organizational infrastructure for a competitive Senate or gubernatorial campaign exists. This paper argues that the geographic evolution of a member's donor coalition provides this missing signal. Using individual-level contribution records from the Database on Ideology, Money in Politics, and Elections (DIME) for 1,337 House members across 23,118 member-election cycles from 1994 to 2022, I estimate discrete-time event history models predicting the decision to run for higher office as a function of donor coalition dynamics. Members whose donor coalitions remain geographically stable, where they exhibit high overlap across consecutive election cycles, are significantly less likely to pursue progressive ambition, with every 10-percentage-point increase in donor overlap associated with a 47% decrease in the odds of running for higher office. However, members who experience geographic expansion in their donor base face a 23% increase in the odds of running for every 10-percentage-point increase in out-of-district donor share. Controlling for electoral safety, district partisanship, ideology, tenure, and era fixed effects these results hold. These findings suggest that donor coalitions function not only as a resource constraint but also as a signal that informs members about their own statewide political standing and that shapes the information environment in which progressive ambition develops.

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1 Introduction

Ambition is at the heart of politics. The willingness of officeholders to seek higher positions drives candidates to emerge in elections, shapes their legislative behavior, and structures the way in which political talent flows from local to national institutions. While there have been decades of research on progressive ambition, a desire to run for higher office, a fundamental question has gone unanswered: how do members of the House of Representatives, early in their careers and before any statewide electoral test, form beliefs about their own viability as statewide candidates?

The existing literature offers research on what triggers the decision to run for higher office once a member has decided they are viable. Rohde (1979) established the foundational framework: members are utility maximizers who weigh the expected benefits of higher office against the costs and risks of running a statewide campaign, including the risk of losing a safe House seat. Maestas et al. (2006) refined this logic by distinguishing between the formation of progressive ambition and the strategic decision to act on it, showing that even static members may harbor suppressed ambitions that emerge when the opportunity costs fall. Hall and Van Houweling (1995) added an intra-institutional dimension, showing that members also weigh the internal value of seniority and leadership positions they would lose by leaving the House.

This literature takes as a given is that members have reasonably accurate beliefs about their statewide electoral prospects. The structural opportunity factors like open seats, favorable partisan conditions, and the absence of strong incumbents are the most salient predictors of the decision to run (Brace, 1984). But these factors operate at the level of the observable opportunity structure. These do not explain how members form the prior beliefs about their own electoral viability that determines whether they pursue an opportunity when it arises. A member who does not believe they can raise the money for a statewide campaign, or who does not believe they have a national political profile worth mobilizing a statewide campaign, may not act even when the structural conditions are favorable.

This paper argues that the geographic evolution of a member's donor coalition provides critical input into a candidates belief formation process. All members of the House must raise campaign funds to secure reelection, and the geographic composition and stability of the resulting donor networks varies substantially across members and over time. I argue that members read these patterns as information about their own political standing beyond their district. A donor coalition that remains concentrated within the congressional district and stable across consecutive election cycles signals reliance on local political networks and reinforces incentives for static ambition. A donor coalition that expands geographically, and draws increasingly on donors from outside their district, particularly from the metro political communities that generates the bulk of partisan and ideological contributions to national campaigns which signal that a broader political support structure exists and may be able to mobilize for a statewide election.

This argument connects three separate literatures that have developed largely in isolation from one another. The ambition literature asks what drives career decisions while treating the information environment as a given. The donor geography literature documents where campaign contributions come from and why, revealing that out-of-district money flows in organized, partisan, and strategically directed patterns (Gimpel et al., 2008), but it does not ask what these patterns signal to candidates that receive them. The surrogate representation literature examines why donors give outside their own districts (Mansbridge, 2003; Baker, 2020), while focusing on the implications for policy responsiveness rather than the career calculus of the recipient. This paper connects these literatures by theorizing that the geographic evolution of donor coalitions generates information that enters the career calculus for candidates, information that the existing literature on ambition has not modeled and the existing literature on campaign finance has not asked for.

To test this argument, I create measures of donor coalition evolution from individual-level contribution records in the DIME dataset and estimate discrete-time event history models predicting the decision to run for Senate, governor, the presidency, or the vice presidency among House members from 1994 to 2022. The main independent variables captures four dimensions of coalition evolution: stability of the donor base across consecutive election cycles as measured by the Jaccard similarity coefficient, the change in the share of out-of-district contributions between cycles, donor turnover, and the share of metro donors giving outside the member's district.

Results support the informational theory. Members that have stable donor coalitions have significantly lower hazards of running for higher office, while members whose donor bases expand geographically face significantly higher hazards. Donor turnover reinforces this expansion finding from the opposite direction. The one hypothesis that is not supported, the relationship between expansion and ambition is strongest when expansion occurs specifically in metro areas, is still informative: approximately 97% of out-of-district donors in the sample are already from a metro, meaning the metro character of out-of-district giving adds no diagnostic information beyond the geographic area of the coalition.

These findings make three contributions to the literature. First, they introduce a new mechanism linking campaign finance to a candidates career behavior, one that operates through information rather than resources. The existing literature treats fundraising capacity as a control variable or a cost in ambition models while this paper displays that the geographic structure of the donor coalition is a signal that shapes the information environment where ambition develops. Second, they add a recipient-side dimension to the surrogate representation literature. Prior research has examined what out-of-district donors want and how member responsiveness responds to out-of-district reliance, and these results demonstrate that the geographic shift in donor support that raises responsiveness concerns also shapes the member's own career calculus. Third, this paper extends the event history approach to the study of congressional careers that takes seriously the temporal dynamics of career decision-making by estimating the hazard of running for higher office as a function of time-varying donor coalition characteristics across the member's full House tenure.

2 State of the Literature

2.1 Career Decisions as Cost-Benefit Calculations Under Uncertainty

Schlesinger (1966) identifies three types of political ambition that structure how politicians approach their careers. Discrete ambition characterizes politicians who seek office for a single term without seeking reelection or higher office. Static ambition characterizes politicians who seek a specific office with the intent of retaining it as long as possible. Progressive ambition characterizes politicians who pursue higher office once they obtain their current position. Building on this career typology, Rohde (1979) argued that members of the House are utility maximizers who would seek higher office whenever the opportunity arises without cost or risk. Static ambition, according to Rohde, is not an innate trait but one developed by the costs and risks associated with seeking higher office. Specifically, the risk of trading a smaller, homogenous, and electorally safe seat for a larger, more heterogeneous, and competitive one.

Later work developed this framework by distinguishing between the formation of progressive ambition and the strategic decision to act on it. Maestas et al. (2006) demonstrated that when opportunity costs are fixed, state legislators are theorized to hold static ambition and did not run for higher office at higher rates, which suggests that even static members may have underlying progressive ambitions suppressed by institutional risk. Maestas (2003) extended this argument by showing that progressively ambitious legislators behave differently in office regardless of whether they ultimately run. These members spend more time monitoring public opinion and building political resources while waiting for a strategic opportunity. All together, the literature on political ambition demonstrates that career decisions are a calculus about the value of higher office and the probability of obtaining higher office.

Hall and Van Houweling (1995) modeled the calculus by placing career decisions in a model of intrainstitutional ambition. House members weigh both the external benefits of statewide office and the internal value of leadership positions they expect to either retain or gain within the House. This internal dimension of ambition demonstrates that the decision to run for higher office involves vacating seniority positions and accumulated influenced in the House which create a strong incentive for static ambition in House members who have invested heavily in their House careers rather than running for higher office.

There are critical gaps in the political ambition literature. Ambition models assume that members possess accurate information about their electoral viability, fundraising capacity, and statewide appeal to a broader voting base. Brace (1984) demonstrates that structural institutional factors like open seats and partisan conditions are significant predictors of members' decision to seek higher office. However, these models fall short on how members form beliefs about their own statewide viability before any statewide election has provided that information. The information environment in which progressive ambition develops is treated as a given, which the gap this present paper addresses by theorizing that donor coalition dynamics help to provide the missing signal.

2.2 Fundraising Networks, Donor Geography, and the Information They Carry

The campaign finance literature has shown that the capacity to raise money is a signal of political viability. Jacobson (1989) demonstrates that higher-quality challengers are strategic actors who respond to favorable opportunity structures and that their fundraising capacity is one of their key indicators of those structures. This logic has been extended to the internal politics of Congress, showing that fundraising for the party has replaced traditional work for internal advancement, making large donations to party candidates a mandatory for members seeking advancement within the party and in committee (Heberlig and Larson, 2012). House members who can create a large fundraising network are positioned well for reelection as well as advancement within the House or higher office.

The political geography of these donor networks has not received enough consideration.

Gimpel et al. (2006) presented results that show contributions are shaped by social networks and spatial context while also being independent of individual-level wealth and political interest, whereas the donor geography shows how the House member is within the political community and not just the demographics of their constituency. Gimpel et al. (2008) demonstrates that the financial ties between congressional candidates and non-resident donors are partisan and strategic rather than access-oriented. Funds flow from a small number of wealthy, highly educated metro districts to competitive districts around the country. The literature reveals that out-of-district donations are not random. It is targeted and partisan, being sent to competitive districts. Bramlett et al. (2011) also finds evidence that a small number of neighborhoods account for a majority of all campaign contributions and that public opinion in these high-donor areas is distinctly cosmopolitan and libertarian compared to the country as a whole. The implication for individual members running for office is that attracting donors from these small donor communities is a form of political positioning and not only a fundraising outcome.

This geographic patterning has increased over time. Gimpel et al. (2008) presented data showing that congressional campaigns were already receiving a majority of individual contributions from non-constituents by the mid-2000s, with funds flowing from a small number of wealthy metro districts to competitive contests across the country. With the introduction of online fundraising platforms, this accelerated the trend by reducing transaction costs for out-of-district donors, creating a structural nationalization of campaign finance (La Raja and Schaffner, 2015). Barber (2016) showed that individual donors target candidates on the ideological edges while PACs focus on moderates, with the ideologically extreme candidates benefiting more from this small-donor revolution. Pildes (2019) furthers this research, demonstrating that the dynamics going viral on social media apply equally to online fundraising. The candidates who attract national donor attention are those who are ideologically aggressive or media-prominent. This growth in out-of-district donating reflects not only a structural change in how money moves but a change in the political profile of a candidate that generates nationally networked donor support.

The nationalization of campaign finance reflects the broader transformation of congressional elections. Jacobson (2015) demonstrates that the traditional incumbency advantage has declined to its lowest levels since the 1950s as elections have become more nationalized and party-centered, with voters increasingly evaluating House members through a national partisan lens rather than a local one. The same forces driving donors to give outside their districts - partisan polarization, ideological sorting, and the erosion of locally-rooted political identities - are also eliminating the district-specific personal vote that once insulated incumbents from national partisan tides. In this political environment, a member's national donor network is not merely a fundraising asset. It is evidence of their standing in a national political community whose support would be essential for a competitive statewide campaign.

What this literature has not asked is what the evolution of a member's donor coalition tells the member themselves about their political standing. The existing literature treats donor geography as an outcome to explain why do donors go where they go, but not as an input into the member's own career calculus. A member watching their donor base expand geographically, especially toward metro areas with outward-facing political networks, is observing something potentially diagnostic about their national profile and statewide appeal. This interpretive gap motivates the theoretical framework developed below.

2.3 Surrogate Representation and the Political Economy of Out-of-District Giving

Mansbridge (2003) defines surrogate representation as the practice of legislators representing constituents outside their own geographic districts. This is a form of representation that lacks any electoral connection because the represented constituents cannot vote for the representative. For donors with the disposable income to give outside their districts, monetary surrogacy provides a channel of influence over the policy-making process that goes beyond geographic electoral boundaries. This surrogacy can address a form of political inequality. Donors whose preferred candidates consistently lose in their home districts can seek representation through contributions elsewhere (Mansbridge, 2003).

Previous research has demonstrated that out-of-district donors are primarily partisan and strategic in orientation. Gimpel et al. (2008) showed that funds flow efficiently from a small number of wealthy congressional districts to competitive districts across the country, driven by partisan goals rather than policy access. This partisan logic means that out-of-district contributions are not randomly distributed but they cluster around competitive contests and around candidates whose ideological profiles they identify with the national donor community. Individual donors are investing in partisan outcomes rather than seeking access to a specific member's legislative agenda.

Barber (2016) demonstrates the ideological dimension of this dynamic, showing that individual donors target candidates on the ideological edges while PACs focus on moderates. Individual donors funding ideologically extreme candidates may be investing in a national partisan project at the cost of local electoral competitiveness contributing to candidates who are "out-of-step" with their districts. When representatives leave a committee, their previous access-oriented PAC donors significantly reduce contributions and redirect funds to newer members on the committee (Powell and Grimmer, 2016), while access-oriented interest groups target incumbents for long-term relationships that provide electoral security across careers (Fouirnaies and Hall, 2014).

Baker (2020) futhers this by showing that individual donors seek surrogate representation for both policy and partisan reasons. What is less understood however is the downstream consequences of these out-of-district flows for the recipients. When a member's donor coalition expands geographically, when an increasing share of contributions arrives from donors outside the district, specifically from metro areas with outward-facing political networks, that member is now receiving a signal about their political standing in the national political community. This signal is not only about their fundraising capacity. This signal demonstrates the size of their political network that would be necessary to support a statewide campaign for higher office, their ideological alignment of the member's political profile with these nationally engaged donors, and the willingness of these strategic partisan investors to direct funds towards a members campaign that they may view as having statewide viability.

2.4 Connecting the Literature: Donor Coalitions as Signals

These three streams of literature have developed separately. The ambition literature asks what drives a member's career decisions but treats the information environment as given. The donor geography literature documents the geographic patterning of contributions but does not ask what those patterns mean for a member's own career calculus. The surrogate representation literature focuses on what out-of-district giving means for policy responsiveness, not what it signals to the recipient about their political prospects.

This paper connects the three literatures by making the argument that the geographic composition and evolution of a member's donor coalition provides information that enters their career calculus. Members make their career decisions under uncertainty. The decision to run for higher office, especially early in a House career before any statewide electoral test, requires the formation of beliefs about their statewide viability without direct voter evidence. A member's donor coalition and it's dynamic provides indirect evidence of their viability. A coalition that remains geographically concentrated and stable signals a reliance on district-based networks and it reinforces their incentive for static ambition. A coalition that expands geographically, especially with metro donor communities, signal that broader political support may exist, thus lowering the perceived probability of competitive fundraising beyond the district.

This treats donor networks as signals that shape the information environment in which ambition develops. It builds off of Rohde (1979)'s utility-maximizing logic, Gimpel et al. (2006, 2008)'s evidence of of geographic donating patterns, and Baker (2020)'s demonstration of surrogate representation. Members whose donor coalitions evolve geographically in ways that expand to suggest national political networks are more likely to exhbit progressive ambition, independent of the electoral and institutional factors that previous literature has shown. Looking at donor stability, stability, turnover, and metro concentration, may predict the timing and likelihood of progressive ambition among House members running in statewide elections.

3 Theory and Hypotheses

3.1 Theory

Members of Congress make career decisions under uncertainty. The decision to run for higher office involves high electoral risk. Members must assess whether they possess the name recognition, the organizational support, and the fundraising capacity beyond their congressional district. This assessment is made under uncertainty and early in a member's career when their future prospects are unclear. The decision to remain in the House or to run for higher office can not only depend on the member's personal ambition but also their assessment of their electoral viability and the financial feasibility of a statewide election. The progressively ambitious path, running for the Senate or a governorship, requires a large fundraising network and support beyond just the local congressional district. Early in their career, they must determine whether this broad donor network exists for them.

Donor coalitions provide the signal. All House members must raise money to secure their reelection, and the geographic composition and the stability of this donor network could convey information about their broader electoral prospects beyond the district. Donor coaltions that remain geographically concentrated to the district and stable across election cycles are more likely to produce static ambition among members of the House because it creates a signal that they rely heavily on district donor networks. However, a donor coalition that expands geographically, specifically through growth in out-of-district or metro donors, is a signal for members that there is a larger network of political support beyond their district and possible statewide viability in an election.

I frame these patterns as distinct donor coalition trajectories. Stable coalitions exhibit higher donor overlap and geographic concentration within a member's district, while growing donor coalitions have higher levels of donor turnover and increasing diversity. These trajectories shape the information environment where members evaluate the costs and benefits of progressive ambition. Shifts toward geographically expansive donor support may lower the perceived financial and organizational costs of seeking higher office, therefore increasing the likelihood of a members progressive ambition. However, stable donor coalitions may create incentives for members to remain in the House, increasing the likelihood of a members static ambition.

3.2 Hypotheses

- **Hypothesis 1:** Members whose donor coalitions remain geographically stable across early career cycles are less likely to pursue progressive ambition.
- **Hypothesis 2:** Members who experience an early increase in the share of out-of-district or metropolitan donors are more likely to pursue progressive ambition.
- **Hypothesis 3:** Members with greater donor turnover between their first and second elections are more likely to exhibit progressive ambition than members with a stable donor overlap.
- **Hypothesis 4:** The relationship between donor coalition expansion and progressive ambition is the strongest when expansion occurs in statewide population centers.

4 Research Design

4.1 Data

This study draws on two primary datasets. The first is the Database on Ideology, Money in Politics, and Elections (DIME), compiled by Adam Bonica. DIME contains individual-

Table 1: Summary Statistics

	Mean	SD	Min	Median	Max	N
Progressive ambition (event)	0.01	0.09	0.00	0.00	1.00	23 118
Donor overlap (Jaccard)	0.13	0.12	0.00	0.12	1.00	10 392
Donor turnover	0.87	0.12	0.00	0.88	1.00	10 392
Outside-donor expansion	0.02	0.24	−1.00	0.01	1.00	10 849
Metro donors giving outside district	0.58	0.29	0.00	0.60	1.00	22 980
Outside-district donor share	0.58	0.29	0.00	0.59	1.00	23 074
Total located donors	2577.15		0.00	160.00	1 150 087.00	23 118
Vote margin	−0.09	0.28	−0.50	−0.07	0.50	14 316
District presidential vote share	0.52	0.14	0.17	0.50	0.96	22 910
Ideology (CFscore)	0.19	0.99	−1.96	0.21	2.62	23 118
Tenure cycles	2.82	3.15	1.00	1.00	22.00	23 118

Unit of analysis is the member-election cycle. Sample: 1994-2022.

level contribution records and candidate-level fundraising and electoral information for state and federal elections from 1979 to 2024, and serves as the foundation for constructing all donor coalition measures. The second dataset is the Legislative Effectiveness Scores (LES) database, which provides member-level measures of legislative productivity and institutional performance used as controls. After merging both datasets and restricting the sample to members of the U.S. House of Representatives with at least one observed election between 1994 and 2022, the analysis retains 1,337 unique members across 23,118 member-election cycle observations. The unit of analysis is the member-election cycle. Table 1 presents summary statistics for all variables used in the analysis. Figures 1 and 2 display the geographic composition of donor networks and the baseline hazard rate over the sample period. Figure 3 shows how the outside-donor share and the rate of progressive ambition co-move across cycles, and Figure 4 shows the cross-cycle relationship between these two quantities. The distribution of the key independent variables is shown in Figure 5.

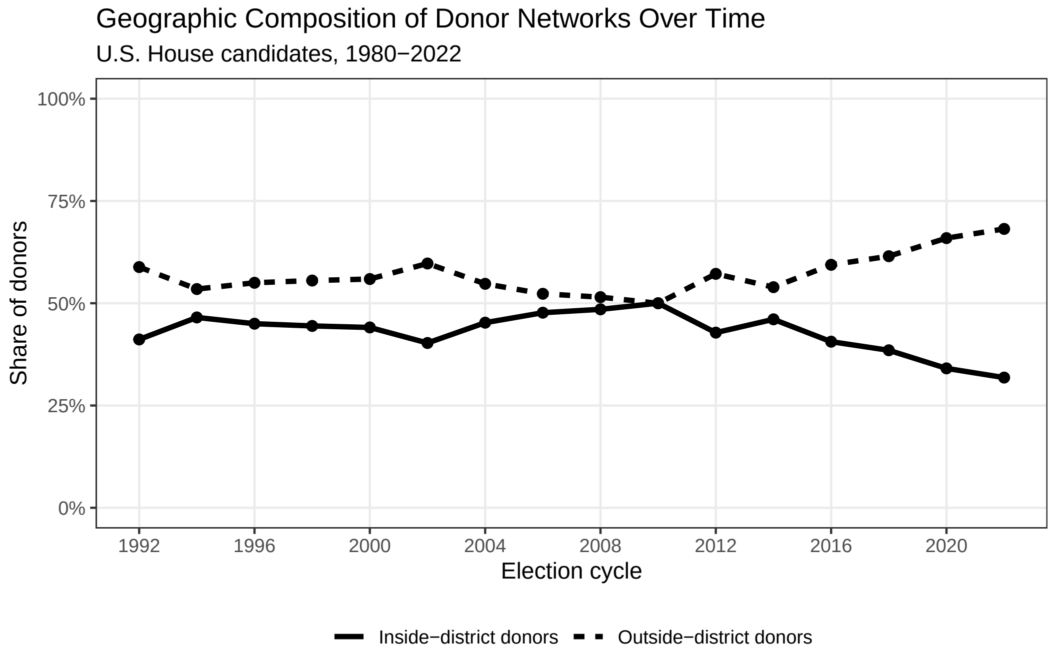

Figure 1: Geographic Composition of Donor Networks Over Time. Average share of inside-district and outside-district donors among U.S. House candidates, 1980–2022. Sample restricted to candidates with at least one located donor.

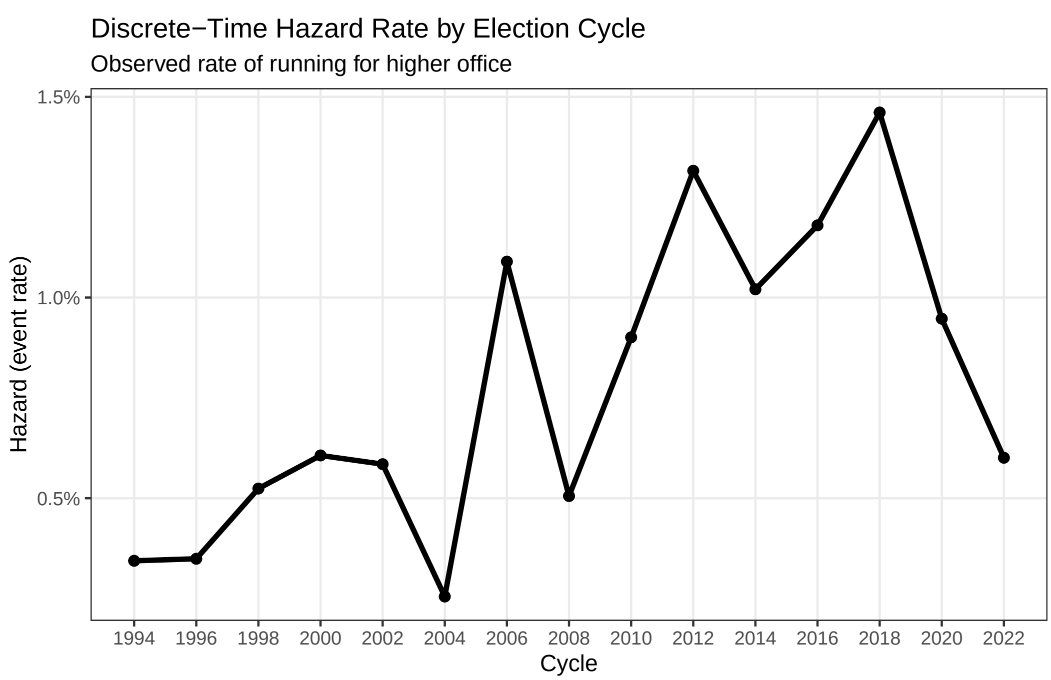

Figure 2: Discrete-Time Hazard Rate by Election Cycle. Observed rate of running for higher office among U.S. House members, 1994–2022.

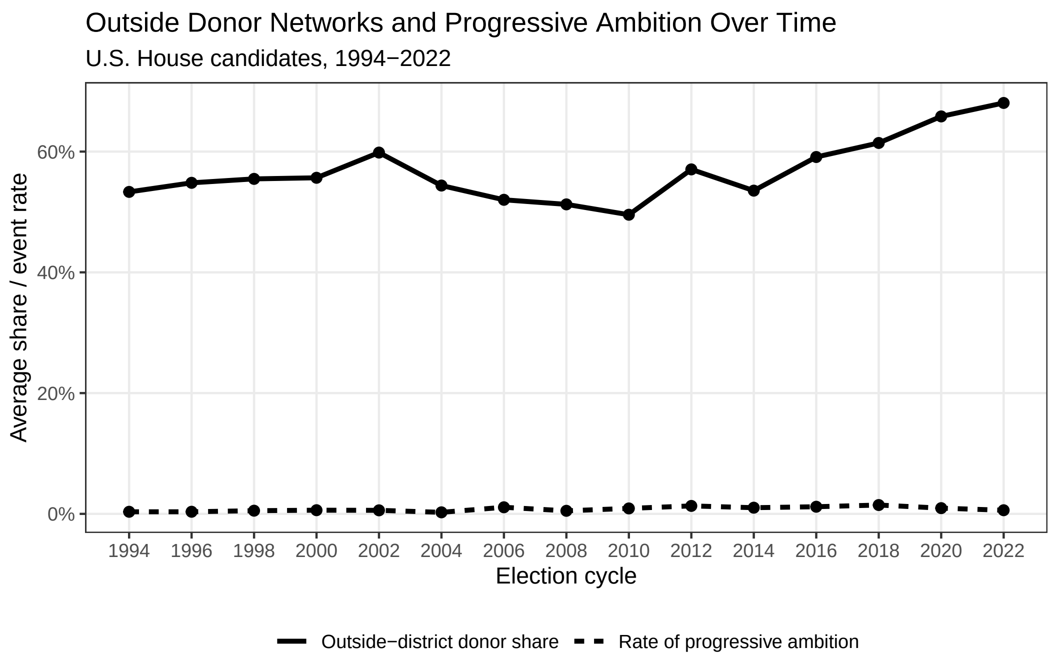

Figure 3: Outside Donor Networks and Progressive Ambition Over Time. Mean outside-district donor share and rate of running for higher office among U.S. House candidates, 1994–2022.

4.2 Dependent Variable

The dependent variable measures progressive ambition as a member's decision to seek higher office. Progressive ambition is operationalized through a member's observed candidacy for running for higher office following Schlesinger (1966) and Rohde (1979). The variable is coded as a binary indicator equal to one in the election cycle in which a member first runs for the Senate, a governorship, the presidency, or the vice presidency, and zero in all prior election cycles. Members who run unsuccessfully for higher office are also coded as progressively ambitious because the decision to run demonstrates their career orientation regardless of the electoral outcome. This coding strategy captures the full ambition decisions observable in the DIME candidacy records and avoids confounding ambition with electoral success.

The dependent variable is modeled using a discrete-time event history framework. Each House member enters the risk set at their first observed House election and exists either when

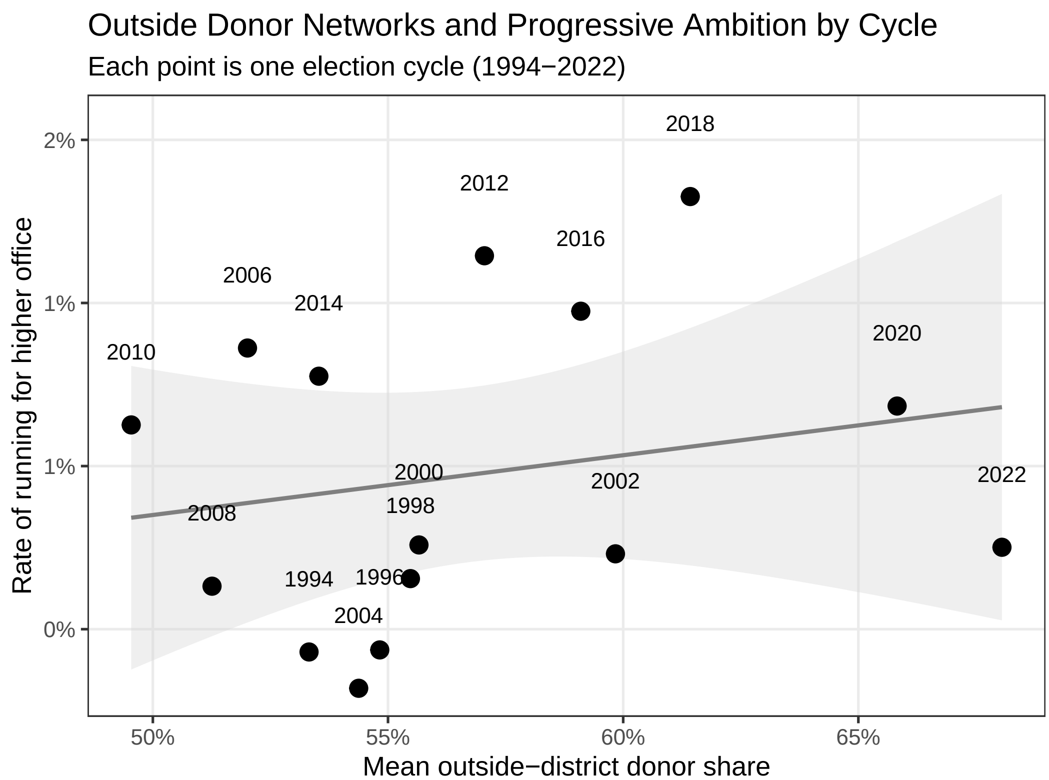

Figure 4: Outside Donor Networks and Progressive Ambition by Cycle. Each point represents one election cycle (1994–2022). The regression line shows the bivariate relationship between mean outside-district donor share and the rate of running for higher office across cycles.

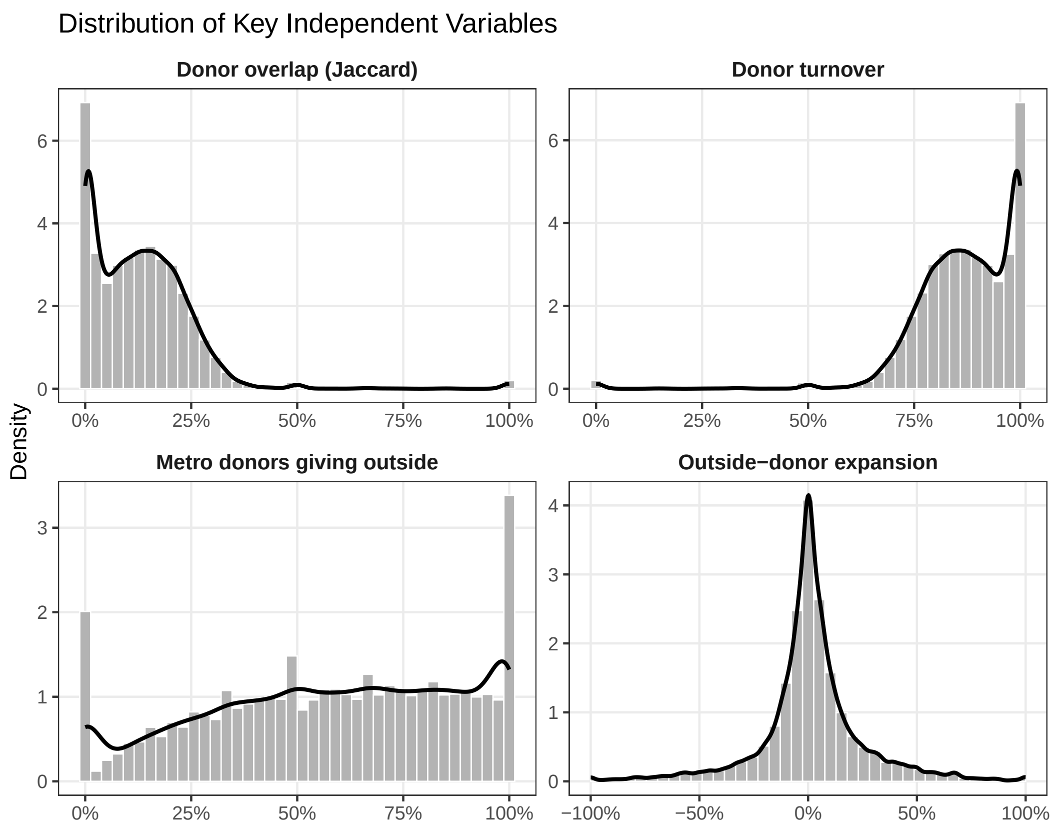

Figure 5: Distribution of Key Independent Variables. Histograms with overlaid density curves for donor overlap (Jaccard), donor turnover, outside-donor expansion, and the share of metro donors giving outside the district. Sample restricted to member-election cycles with non-missing values, 1994–2022.

they run for higher office, the event, or when they leave the House without having done so, right censoring. This structure accounts for the fact that members go through the hazard of running for higher office at each election cycle they remain in the House, and earlier elections provide information about their career trajectories even for members who never seek higher office. This creates a dataset in which each row represents one member in one election cycle, and the dependent variable records whether the event occured in that period.

4.3 Independent Variables

The main independent variables captures four distinct dimensions of donor coalition evolution across consecutive election cycles, each corresponding to one of the four hypotheses.

Donor stability is measured using the Jaccard similarity coefficient (Tan et al., 2018), a standard set similarity index that captures the proportion of a combined pool shared across two observations, calculated across adjacent election cycles. For each member, I identify the set of unique donors which is defined by their DIME contributor identifier in cycle t and in cycle $t-2$, and compute the ratio of their intersection to the union of these two sets. Higher values indicate greater continuity between consecutive donor coalitions, reflecting a stable and geographically concentrated donor base. Lower values indicate greater turnover and a restructuring of the coalition. Because this measure requires at least two observed elections, models using donor overlap and donor turnover are estimated on a somewhat smaller sample than models using the level-based outside-district share.

Outside-donor expansion measures the change in the share of total individual contributions that originate from outside the member's congressional district between consecutive election cycles. Using the contributor district field in DIME, standardized to a two-character state abbreviation plus two-digit district number format, I first calculate the share of located donors in each cycle who contributed from outside the member's district, then take the first difference between cycle t and cycle $t-2$. Positive values indicate geographic expansion of the donor coalition; negative values indicate contraction. This change based measure captures the dynamic signal emphasized in the theory rather than a static cross-sectional level.

Metro donor network activity measures the share of metro donors who contribute outside the member's district. I classify donors as metro using a spatial join between donor latitude-longitude coordinates and U.S. Census Bureau Core-Based Statistical Area (CBSA) shapefiles. Among donors with identifiable geographic coordinates, I classify each as metro if their coordinates fall within any CBSA boundary and as non-metro otherwise. The key measure: the share of metro donors giving outside the district, captures the outward-facing character of a member's metro donor network, and serves as the main independent variable in the H4 interaction model.

The H4 model tests whether the effect of outside-donor expansion is amplified when metro donor networks are already oriented outward. I estimate this as an interaction between outside-donor expansion and the metro-outside share.

4.4 Control Variables

All models include controls for factors known to shape both donor coalitions and ambition decisions. Log donor pool size accounts for the fact that larger donor networks mechanically produce more geographic diversity and that members with large fundraising operations may have different ambition profiles than those relying on small local bases. Vote margin controls for the member's most recent electoral safety, since vulnerable members face higher opportunity costs from abandoning a competitive seat and also may be less likely to pursue higher office. The district presidential vote share captures the partisan lean of the district, which shapes both the member's electoral security and the ideological composition of the local donor pool. Ideology, measured by the candidate's CFscore from DIME, accounts for the possibility that more extreme members attract different donor networks and face different opportunity structures for statewide office. Tenure cycles controls for the career stage of the member, as ambition decisions are likely to cluster at particular points in congressional careers. Party fixed effects for Democrats, Republicans, and third-party or independent members are used to account for the possibility that the two parties provide systematically different pathways to higher office.

All models include era fixed effects using four bins: 1994-2000, 2002-2010, 2012-2018, and 2020-2022. They account for the temporal variation in the baseline hazard of running for higher office. Individual election-cycle fixed effects are estimated as a robustness check but are not used in the main models because the sparse distribution of events across 15 individual cycles produces complete separation in several cells which inflate standard errors on the time parameters without affecting the substantive estimates on the main independent variables.

4.5 Estimation

I estimate discrete-time logistic regression models with the person-period dataset as the unit of analysis. This approach, recommended by Singer and Willett (1993) and Box-Steffensmeier and Jones (2004) for political science applications, treats each member-cycle as an independent observation conditional on survival to that period, and estimates the log-odds of the hazard as a function of the independent variables and the baseline hazard captured by the era fixed effects. Standard errors are not clustered in the main models because the event history structure already conditions on the member's prior history through the risk-set construction, though clustered specifications are available as robustness checks.

Models involving change-based donor measures like outside-donor expansion, Jaccard overlap, and donor turnover require at least two observed elections and are therefore estimated on smaller samples than the metro-level models, which use cross-sectional donor composition measures. I make note of sample sizes explicitly in the results tables. Predicted probabilities and marginal effects are calculated by setting all covariates to their observed medians and varying the main independent variable across its fifth to ninety-fifth percentile range, evaluated separately for each era to illustrate how the relationship between donor coalition dynamics and progressive ambition varies across the historical periods in the sample.

5 Results

Table 2 presents discrete-time hazard models estimating the log-odds of a House member running for higher office as a function of donor coalition dynamics, controlling for electoral safety, district partisanship, ideology, tenure, party, and era fixed effects. I discuss each hypothesis in turn, while using predicted probabilities to illustrate the magnitude of these effects.

5.1 Hypothesis 1: Donor Coalition Stability

Model 1 tests whether members with stable donor coalitions are less likely to pursue progressive ambition. The results provide support for this hypothesis. The coefficient on overlap is negative and statistically significant ($\beta = -6.34$, $SE = 2.18$, $p = .004$), indicating that members whose donor coalitions show high continuity across multiple election cycles face a substantially lower hazard of running for higher office. Every 10-percentage-point increase in donor overlap is associated with a 47% decrease in the odds of running for higher office ($e^{-6.34\times0.10} = 0.53$). Figure 6 translates this estimate into predicted probabilities. For a median Democrat in the 2012-2018 era, the period with the highest baseline hazard in the sample, moving from low donor overlap (5th percentile, approximately 5%) to a high donor overlap (95th percentile, approximately 47%) is associated with a decline in the predicted probability of running for higher office from roughly 5% to under 1%. The effect is somewhat attenuated in the earlier eras but remains negative and monotonically decreasing across the full range of the variable. Figure 7 shows that the marginal effect of overlap on the probability of running peaks at moderate values of overlap, where the predicted probability is closest to 0.5 and the logistic curve is steepest, and falls off at the extremes, a standard feature of

Table 2: Discrete-Time Hazard Models of Progressive Ambition

	H1: Overlap	H2: Expansion	H3: Turnover	H4: Interaction
Donor overlap (stability)	−6.337**			
	(2.184)			
Donor turnover			6.337**	
			(2.184)	
Outside-donor expansion		2.050***		1.334
		(0.602)		(1.925)
Metro donors giving outside				0.692
				(0.723)
Expansion × metro donors				0.500
				(2.327)
Log donor pool size	0.232**	0.209*	0.232**	0.192*
	(0.082)	(0.085)	(0.082)	(0.087)
Vote margin	−5.376***	−5.434***	−5.376***	−5.353***
	(0.850)	(0.806)	(0.850)	(0.810)
District presidential vote	−2.048	−1.006	−2.048	−1.233
	(1.240)	(1.231)	(1.240)	(1.241)
Ideology (CFscore)	0.622	0.469	0.622	0.481
	(0.449)	(0.433)	(0.449)	(0.432)
Tenure cycles	0.048	0.027	0.048	0.022
	(0.043)	(0.046)	(0.043)	(0.046)
Num. Obs.	7132	7367	7132	7356
AIC	488.8	495.2	488.8	497.9

Entries are logit coefficients with standard errors in parentheses. Era and party fixed effects included but omitted from display.

$^{*}p < 0.05$
$^{**}p < 0.01$
$^{***}p < 0.001$

marginal effects in nonlinear models.

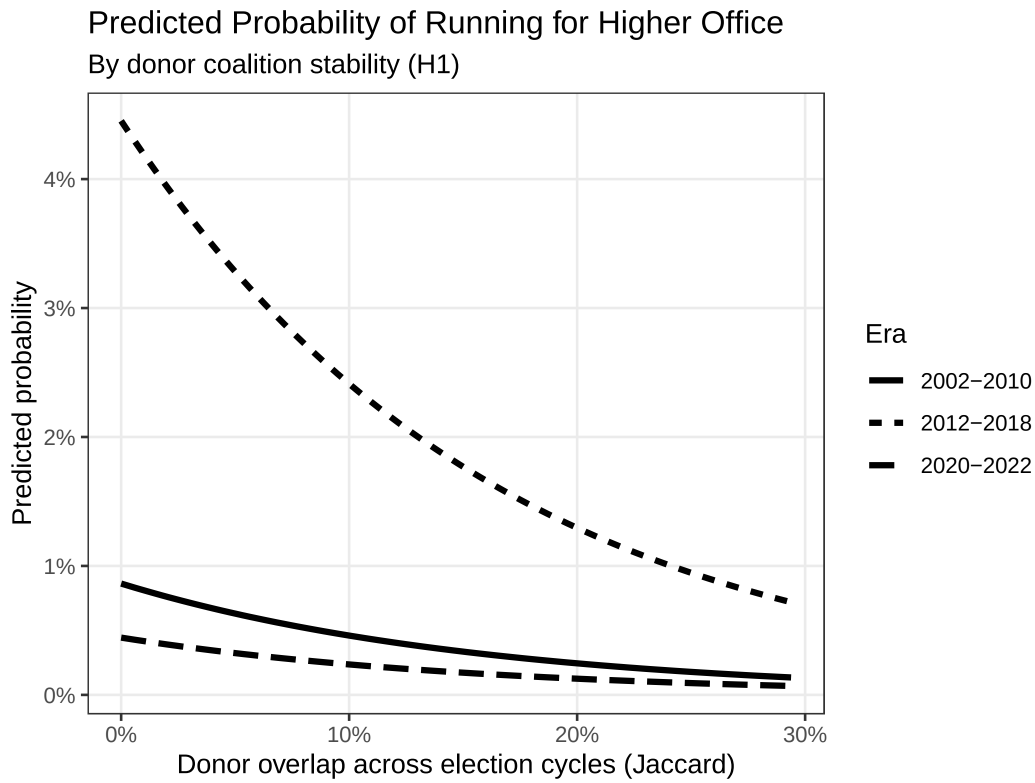

Figure 6: Predicted Probability of Running for Higher Office by Donor Coalition Stability (H1). Predictions generated from Model 1 (Table 2) holding all covariates at their observed medians. Party set to Democrat. The x-axis spans the 5th to 95th percentile of the observed Jaccard overlap distribution.

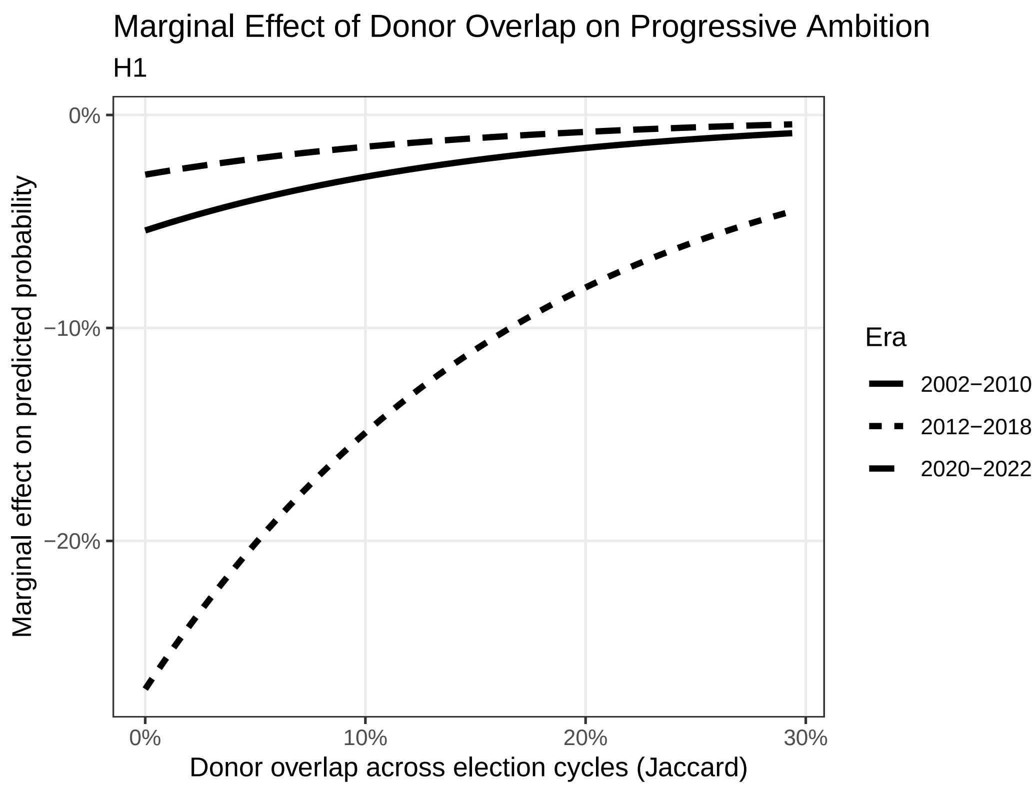

Figure 7: Marginal Effect of Donor Overlap on the Probability of Running for Higher Office (H1). Marginal effects calculated as $\hat{\beta} \cdot \hat{p}(1 - \hat{p})$ at each value of the x-axis, holding all other covariates at their observed medians. Party set to Democrat.

The era fixed effects deserve mention. Relative to the 1994-2000 reference period, the 2012-2018 era is associated with a substantially elevated baseline hazard ($\beta = 2.73$, $p < .001$), consistent with the descriptive pattern in Figure 2 showing a spike in progressive ambition during those cycles. The 2002-2010 era also shows a modestly elevated hazard ($\beta = 1.05$, $p = .043$), while the most recent 2020-2022 era does not differ significantly from the earliest period.

5.2 Hypothesis 2: Outside-Donor Expansion

Model 2 tests whether growth in the share of out-of-district donors increases the likelihood of progressive ambition. The coefficient on outside-donor expansion is positive and highly significant ($\beta = 2.05$, $SE = 0.60$, $p < .001$), supporting Hypothesis 2. Every 10-percentage-point increase in the outside-donor share is associated with a 23% increase in the odds of running for higher office ($e^{2.05 \times 0.10} = 1.23$). A one-unit increase, equivalent to moving from a fully district-concentrated donor base to a fully out-of-district one, is associated with a 2.05-point increase in the log-odds of running. More substantively, Figure 8 shows the predicted probability of running for higher office as outside-donor expansion varies from its 5th to 95th percentile (approximately -30 to $+30$ percentage points). For the 2012-2018 era, this range corresponds to a shift in predicted probability from roughly 1% to nearly 5%. The effect is smaller but consistent in sign across the 2002-2010 and 2020-2022 eras. The marginal effects in Figure 9 confirm the pattern is roughly linear across the observed range, with no strong evidence of threshold or acceleration effects.

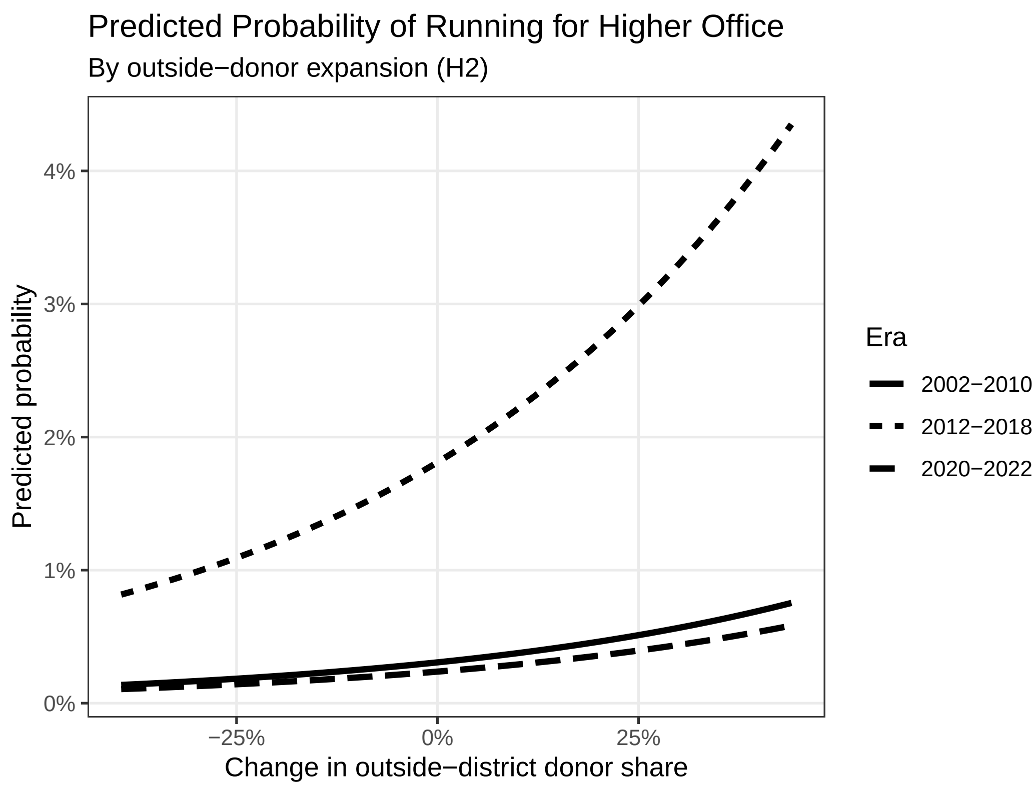

Figure 8: Predicted Probability of Running for Higher Office by Outside-Donor Expansion (H2). Predictions generated from Model 2 (Table 2) holding all covariates at their observed medians. Party set to Democrat. The x-axis spans the 5th to 95th percentile of the observed expansion distribution.

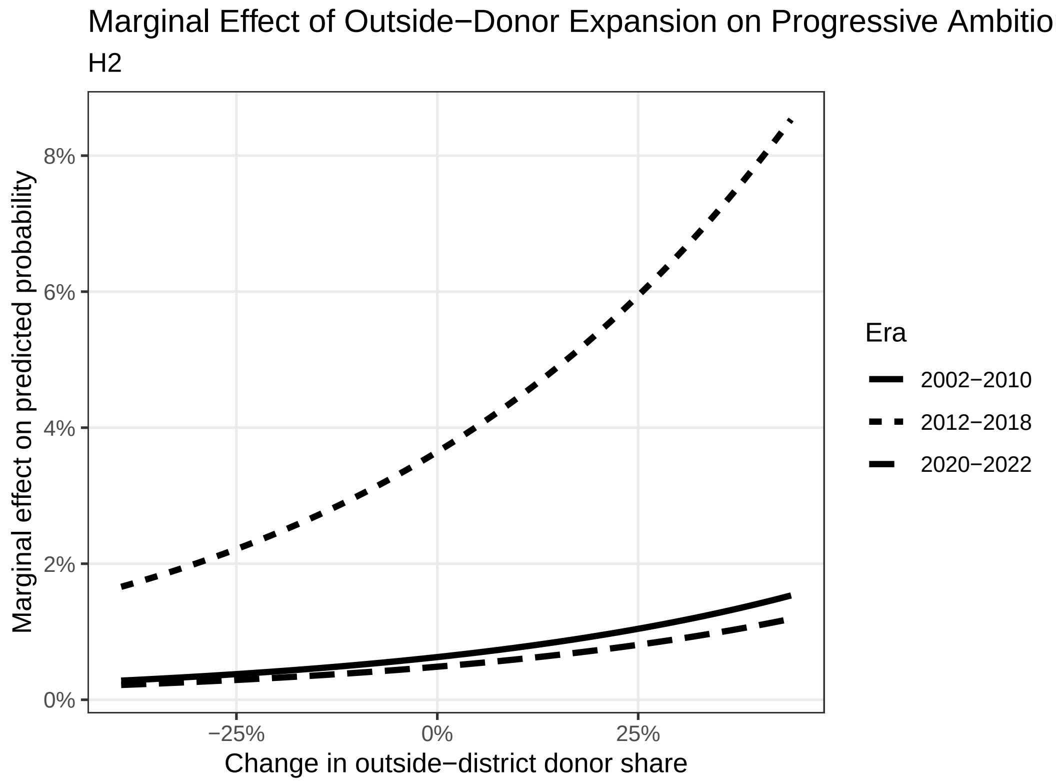

Figure 9: Marginal Effect of Outside-Donor Expansion on the Probability of Running for Higher Office (H2). Marginal effects calculated as $\hat{\beta} \cdot \hat{p}(1 - \hat{p})$ at each value of the x-axis, holding all other covariates at their observed medians. Party set to Democrat.

5.3 Hypothesis 3: Donor Turnover

Model 3 replaces donor overlap with its complement, donor turnover, as an additional test of the stability hypothesis from the opposite direction. As expected given the mathematical relationship between the two measures, the coefficient on turnover is equal in magnitude and opposite in sign to the overlap coefficient ($\beta = 6.34$, $SE = 2.18$, $p = .004$). Every 10-percentage-point increase in donor turnover is associated with an 89% increase in the odds of running for higher office ($e^{6.34 \times 0.10} = 1.89$). Members with higher donor turnover, meaning a larger share of their combined donor pool did not contribute in both adjacent cycles, face a higher hazard of running for higher office, consistent with Hypothesis 3. The substantive interpretation mirrors H1: greater instability in the donor coalition is associated with progressively ambitious career behavior. The fact that H1 and H3 produce mirror-image results on the same underlying variation provides a useful internal consistency check on the measurement strategy. Figure 10 shows predicted probabilities and Figure 11 shows the corresponding marginal effects.

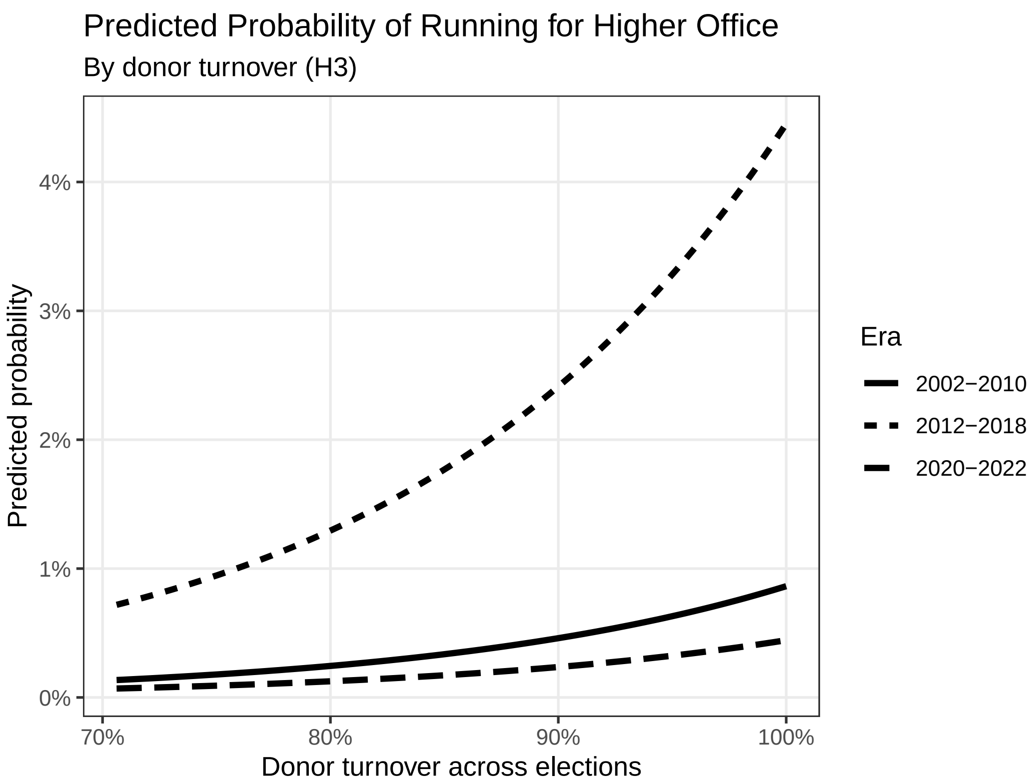

Figure 10: Predicted Probability of Running for Higher Office by Donor Turnover (H3). Predictions generated from Model 3 (Table 2) holding all covariates at their observed medians. Party set to Democrat. The x-axis spans the 5th to 95th percentile of the observed turnover distribution.

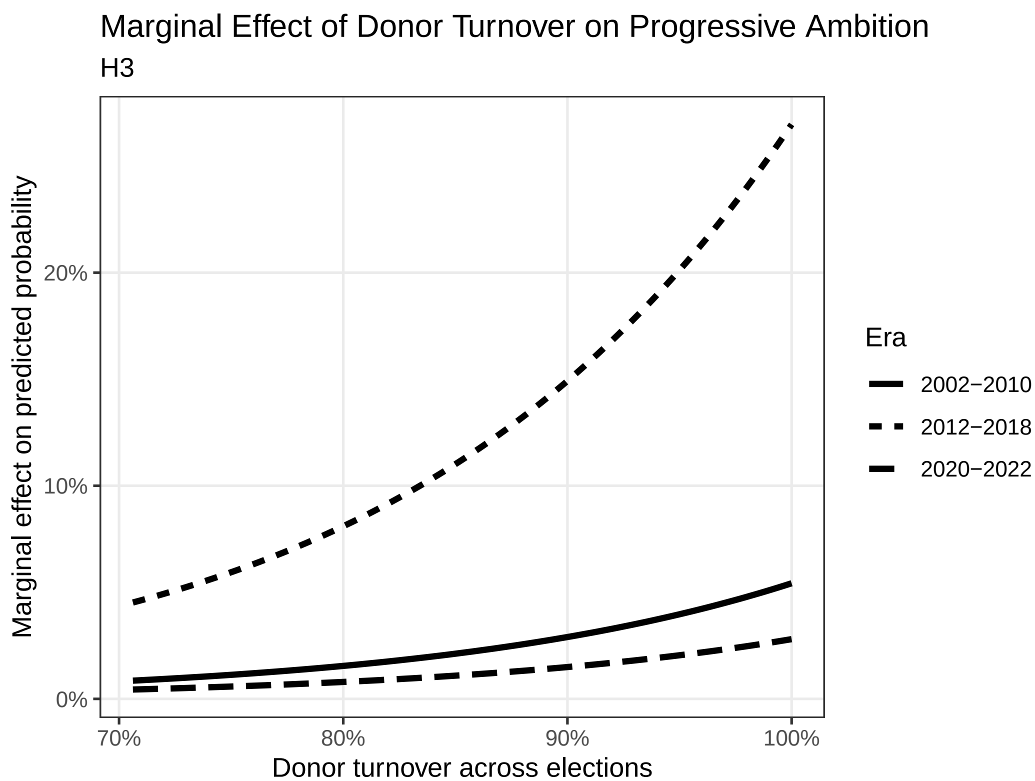

Figure 11: Marginal Effect of Donor Turnover on the Probability of Running for Higher Office (H3). Marginal effects calculated as $\hat{\beta} \cdot \hat{p}(1-\hat{p})$ at each value of the x-axis, holding all other covariates at their observed medians. Party set to Democrat.

5.4 Hypothesis 4: The Metro Interaction

Model 4 adds an interaction between outside-donor expansion and the share of metro donors giving outside the district. The interaction term is small and not statistically significant ($\beta = 0.50$, $SE = 2.33$, $p = .830$), and neither the expansion nor the metro variable is individually significant once the interaction is included. Hypothesis 4 is not supported. Figure 12 illustrates why: the three predicted probability lines corresponding to low, median, and high metro-outside donor shares are nearly indistinguishable across the full range of outside-donor expansion in all three eras. The null interaction is reinforced by Figure 13, which shows the marginal effect of expansion on the probability of running barely varies across metro donor network levels. Together, these results suggest that what drives progressive ambition is the overall geographic spread of the donor coalition rather than the specifically metro character of out-of-district giving. This is perhaps unsurprising given that approximately 97% of out-of-district donors in the sample are already from ametro, leaving little residual variation for the interaction to capture.

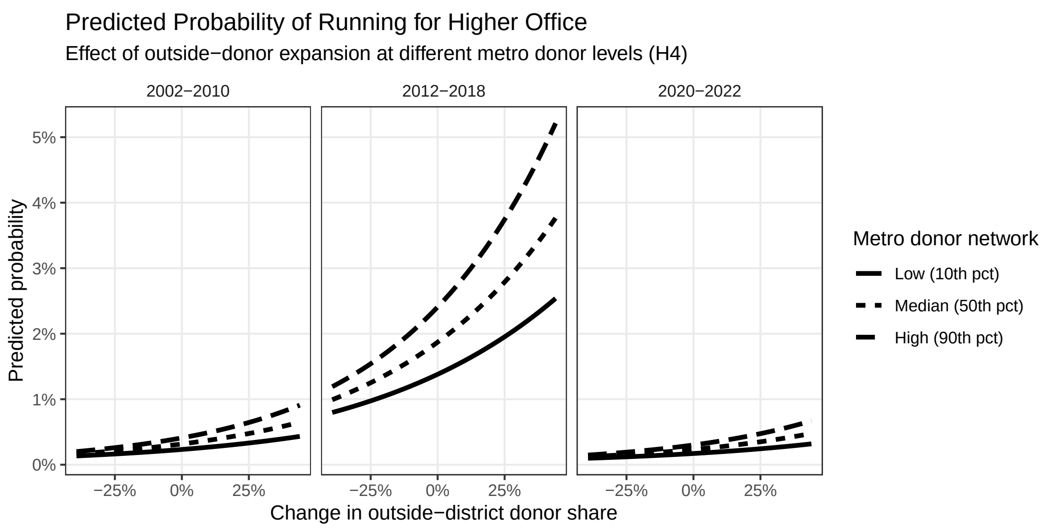

Figure 12: Predicted Probability of Running for Higher Office by Outside-Donor Expansion and Metro Donor Network Strength (H4). Predictions generated from Model 4 (Table 2) holding all covariates at their observed medians. Party set to Democrat. Lines correspond to the 10th, 50th, and 90th percentiles of the metro-outside donor share distribution. Panels show results for each era.

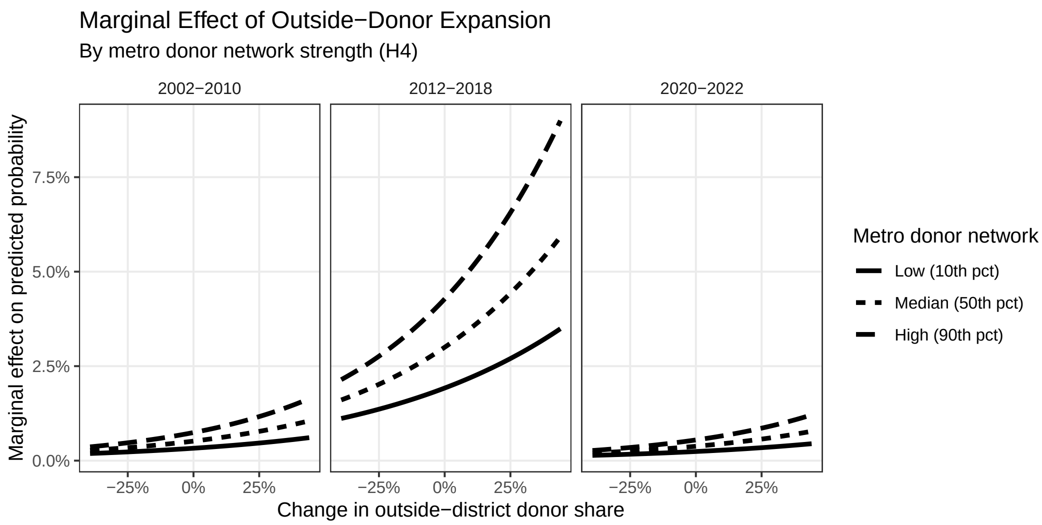

Figure 13: Marginal Effect of Outside-Donor Expansion on the Probability of Running for Higher Office by Metro Donor Network Strength (H4). Marginal effects calculated as $(\hat{\beta}_{\text{expansion}} + \hat{\beta}_{\text{interaction}} \cdot \text{metro}) \cdot \hat{p}(1 - \hat{p})$ at each value of the x-axis. Lines correspond to the 10th, 50th, and 90th percentiles of the metro-outside donor share distribution. Panels show results for each era.

5.5 Controls

Over the four models, vote margin is negative and significant. This shows evidence that electorally safe members are less likely to risk their seats for higher office. This is consistent with previous literature, opportunity cost logic in Rohde (1979). The logged donor pool size is positive and significant which suggests that members with larger fundraising networks have lower perceived financial barriers to statewide campaigns. The district presidential vote share is negative in Models 1 to 4 ($p \approx .10$), showing some evidence that members in Democratic-leaning districts are less likely to run for statewide elections, however this does not reach significant levels. Ideology, tenure, and a members party are also not significant predictors of progressive ambition.

6 Conclusion

The research question for this paper was: can changes in a member's donor coalition change their career trajectory? The evidence presented here suggests that donor coalitions can have an impact on a member's career trajectory. Using a discrete-time event history framework and individual-level contribution records from the DIME dataset, the results show that geographic composition and stability of a House member's donor coalition is associated with the probability of running for higher office, independent of the electoral and institutional factors that the previous literature has identified as the primary variables of progressive ambition.

Two findings from the results stand out. First, donor coalition stability weakens a member's progressive ambition. House members whose donor bases exhibit high continuity across consecutive elections face substantially lower hazards of running for the Senate, a governorship, or the president. Every 10-percentage-point increase in donor overlap is associated with a 47% decrease in the odds of running for higher office. Therefore, the donor coalition is not only a fundraising stream for members but it is also a structural anchor that ties members to House focused careers. Second, geographic expansion of the donor coalition increases a members progressive ambition. Members who experience growth in their out-of-district donor share across consecutive elections were significantly more likely to run for higher office, with every 10-percentage-point increase in outside-donor expansion creating a 23% increase in the odds of running for higher office. This result is consistent with the informational theory: the expanding out-of-district donor base signals that a member's political profile goes beyond their congressional district, thus lowering the perceived costs of a statewide campaign.

The hypothesis that did not receive support is the metro concentration hypothesis. The interaction between outside-donor expansion and the share of metro donors giving to outside districts is small and not statistically significant. While the result is null, it is still informative because approximately 97% of out-of-district donors in the sample are already from a metro area, meaning there is likely insufficient residual variation in metro donors for out-of-district giving for the interaction to actually capture in the model. This result suggests that what actually matters for the career signal is the overall geographic span of the coalition rather than its metro composition. So, once a donor is giving outside the district, the signal value is largely independent of whether that donor lives in a metro area.

These results support the theory of donor coalitions as signal generators for statewide support. Members do not simply respond to donor networks as resource constraints, but they observe the geographic evolution of their fundraising coalitions as evidence about their own statewide political standing. A coalition that remains concentrated and stable communicates that the member's support is local and bounded. A coalition that expands outward communicates that a broader network exists and can potentially be mobilized for a statewide race. These signals enter the career calculus along with the structural opportunity factors such as open seats, partisan conditions, and tenure that the previous literature has demonstrated.

7 Discussion

Existing models treat the information environment as given: members know their electoral viability and fundraising capacity, and they respond to structural opportunity. This paper argues that the information environment is itself constructed through the fundraising process. Members learn about their statewide viability by observing who gives to them, from where, and how that pattern changes over time. This reframes the donor-candidate relationship from a purely financial one to an informational one. The donor coalition is a feedback mechanism, not just a funding resource.

This informational argument connects to a broader literature on political signaling and candidate emergence. Jacobson (1989) showed that high-quality challengers respond to favorable opportunity structures, but the question of how candidates assess their own quality in the first place has received less attention. These findings suggests that the geographic evolution of fundraising networks is a mechanism, particularly early in a House career before any statewide electoral test has revealed the member's appeal beyond the district.

These findings also have implications for the surrogate representation literature. Baker (2020) showed that out-of-district donors seek surrogate representation for both policy and partisan reasons. The present paper adds a recipient-side dimension: member's who receive those out-of-district contributions are not merely accumulating resources but receiving a signal about their national political standing. The geography of surrogate representation thus has a second-order consequence for democratic representation that the existing literature has not addressed. It shapes the career incentives of the very legislators whose responsiveness the literature is concerned with.

Three limitations deserve acknowledgment. The first is the endogeneity concern. The most straightforward alternative interpretation of the results is reverse causality: members who already intend to run for higher office may actively seek out-of-district donors in anticipation of a statewide campaign, meaning that the expanding donor coalition is a consequence of latent progressive ambition rather than a cause of it. The present design cannot fully tease this out. The use of change-based measures and the discrete-time event history structure provide some protection against this concern where donor expansion at cycle t predicts the event at cycle t or later, and the models condition on prior career history, but a credible causal identification strategy would require an instrument or quasi-experimental variation that the available data do not readily provide. Future work using candidate surveys that capture latent ambition separately from observed candidacy, along the lines of the Candidate Emergence Study (Maestas et al., 2006), could help disentangle these pathways.

The second limitation is the null result on the metro interaction. Finding that 97% of out-of-district donors are already from a metro area means the H4 test is underpowered by construction. A more precise test of the metro concentration hypothesis would require data that can distinguish more precisely among different types of metro donors. For example, distinguishing donors from major national fundraising centers like New York and Los Angeles from donors in smaller metropolitan areas or would examine the hypothesis in an earlier period when out-of-district giving was less universally metro in origin.

The third limitation concerns the measurement of the dependent variable. Progressive ambition is operationalized here as the decision to run for higher office, which conflates members who run strategically after careful planning with those who run opportunistically in response to sudden openings. The ambition literature distinguishes between the formation of progressive ambition and the decision to act on it (Maestas et al., 2006), and the present measure captures only the latter. Members whose donor coalitions expand but who face no open seat or favorable conditions may be progressively ambitious without ever exhibiting the candidacy behavior that triggers the event in the hazard model. This right-censoring of latent ambition likely attenuates the estimated effects.

Several extensions follow from this work. The most important is to extend the informational framework to earlier career stages. The present analysis begins when members enter the House, but the signals that shape career decisions likely operate earlier like at the state legislative level, before a member has sought federal office at all. If metro donor networks and geographic coalition expansion predict congressional candidacy among state legislators, this would strengthen the theoretical argument and extend its scope.

A second extension is to examine heterogeneity in the donor signal. The current models treat all out-of-district expansion as equivalent, but the informational content of a donor coalition may vary by who is giving. Expansion driven by small-dollar ideological donors activated by a viral moment may carry different career information than expansion driven by large access-oriented donors from financial or legal sectors. The DIME data contain sufficient information to construct these distinctions, and future work could examine whether the type of out-of-district expansion matters as much as the overall level.

A third direction is to examine a feedback loop between career decisions and legislative behavior. Maestas (2003) demonstrated that the progressively ambitious legislators monitor public opinion more closely than the statically ambitious legislators. If donor coalition expansion shapes progressive ambition, then it may also shape legislative behavior through this process. Members who observe their donor bases expanding may begin behaving more like statewide candidates before they formally announce, moderating their positions, seeking national media attention, or shifting their committee priorities. Testing this behavioral prediction would connect the present findings to the representation literature in a direct way.

Finally, the relationship between donor coalition dynamics and career decisions likely varies across the structural conditions documented in the descriptive results. The 2012-2018 spike in the baseline hazard matches with a period of particularly intense nationalization of campaign finance and electoral politics (Jacobson, 2015). Whether the informational value of out-of-district donor expansion is larger or smaller during periods of high nationalization, when out-of-district money is more common and therefore potentially less diagnostic, is an open question that the present design cannot answer but that longitudinal variation in the data could identify.

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Table 3: Robustness: Donor Overlap (Jaccard) and Progressive Ambition

	(1) Minimal	(2) + Ideology/Party	(3) + Vote margin	(4) Full
Donor overlap (Jaccard)	−10.160***	−10.811***	−5.834**	−6.337**
	(1.363)	(1.382)	(2.149)	(2.184)
Log donor pool size	0.162***	0.186***	0.241**	0.232**
	(0.034)	(0.036)	(0.082)	(0.082)
Vote margin			−5.241***	−5.376***
			(0.835)	(0.850)
District presidential vote				−2.048
				(1.240)
Ideology (CFscore)		0.056	0.517	0.622
		(0.232)	(0.451)	(0.449)
Tenure cycles	0.015	0.020	0.042	0.048
	(0.023)	(0.023)	(0.044)	(0.043)
Num. Obs.	10 392	10 392	7219	7132
AIC	1338.6	1335.2	490.6	488.8

Entries are logit coefficients with standard errors in parentheses. Era and party fixed effects included in all models but omitted from display.

* $p < 0.05$
** $p < 0.01$
*** $p < 0.001$

A Robustness Checks

Table 4: Robustness: Outside-Donor Expansion and Progressive Ambition

	(1) Minimal	(2) + Ideology/Party	(3) + Vote margin	(4) Full
Outside-donor expansion	1.552***	1.515***	2.116***	2.050***
	(0.340)	(0.341)	(0.599)	(0.602)
Log donor pool size	0.074*	0.080*	0.217*	0.209*
	(0.036)	(0.037)	(0.085)	(0.085)
Vote margin			−5.357***	−5.434***
			(0.799)	(0.806)
District presidential vote				−1.006
				(1.231)
Ideology (CFscore)		−0.037	0.434	0.469
		(0.228)	(0.434)	(0.433)
Tenure cycles	−0.018	−0.015	0.024	0.027
	(0.025)	(0.025)	(0.046)	(0.046)
Num. Obs.	10 849	10 849	7458	7367
AIC	1390.9	1395.4	494.7	495.2

Entries are logit coefficients with standard errors in parentheses. Era and party fixed effects included in all models but omitted from display.

* $p < 0.05$
** $p < 0.01$
*** $p < 0.001$

Table 5: Robustness: Donor Turnover and Progressive Ambition

	(1) Minimal	(2) + Ideology/Party	(3) + Vote margin	(4) Full
Donor turnover	10.160***	10.811***	5.834**	6.337**
	(1.363)	(1.382)	(2.149)	(2.184)
Log donor pool size	0.162***	0.186***	0.241**	0.232**
	(0.034)	(0.036)	(0.082)	(0.082)
Vote margin			−5.241***	−5.376***
			(0.835)	(0.850)
District presidential vote				−2.048
				(1.240)
Ideology (CFscore)		0.056	0.517	0.622
		(0.232)	(0.451)	(0.449)
Tenure cycles	0.015	0.020	0.042	0.048
	(0.023)	(0.023)	(0.044)	(0.043)
Num. Obs.	10 392	10 392	7219	7132
AIC	1338.6	1335.2	490.6	488.8

Entries are logit coefficients with standard errors in parentheses. Era and party fixed effects included in all models but omitted from display.

* $p < 0.05$
** $p < 0.01$
*** $p < 0.001$

Table 6: Robustness: Main Models with Cycle Fixed Effects

	H1: Overlap (cycle FE)	H2: Expansion (cycle FE)	H3: Turnover (cycle F
Donor overlap (stability)	−6.041**		
	(2.205)		
Donor turnover			6.041**
			(2.205)
Outside-donor expansion		2.157***	
		(0.652)	
Log donor pool size	0.238**	0.232**	0.238**
	(0.085)	(0.088)	(0.085)
Vote margin	−5.428***	−5.566***	−5.428***
	(0.911)	(0.862)	(0.911)
District presidential vote	−2.339	−1.245	−2.339
	(1.323)	(1.311)	(1.323)
Ideology (CFscore)	0.717	0.548	0.717
	(0.457)	(0.437)	(0.457)
Tenure cycles	0.057	0.031	0.057
	(0.044)	(0.046)	(0.044)
Num. Obs.	7132	7367	7132
AIC	491.4	495.9	491.4

Entries are logit coefficients with standard errors in parentheses. Individual cycle dummies included but omitted from display. Cycle fixed effects produce separation in thin cells; era fixed effects are preferred main models.

* $p < 0.05$
** $p < 0.01$
*** $p < 0.001$

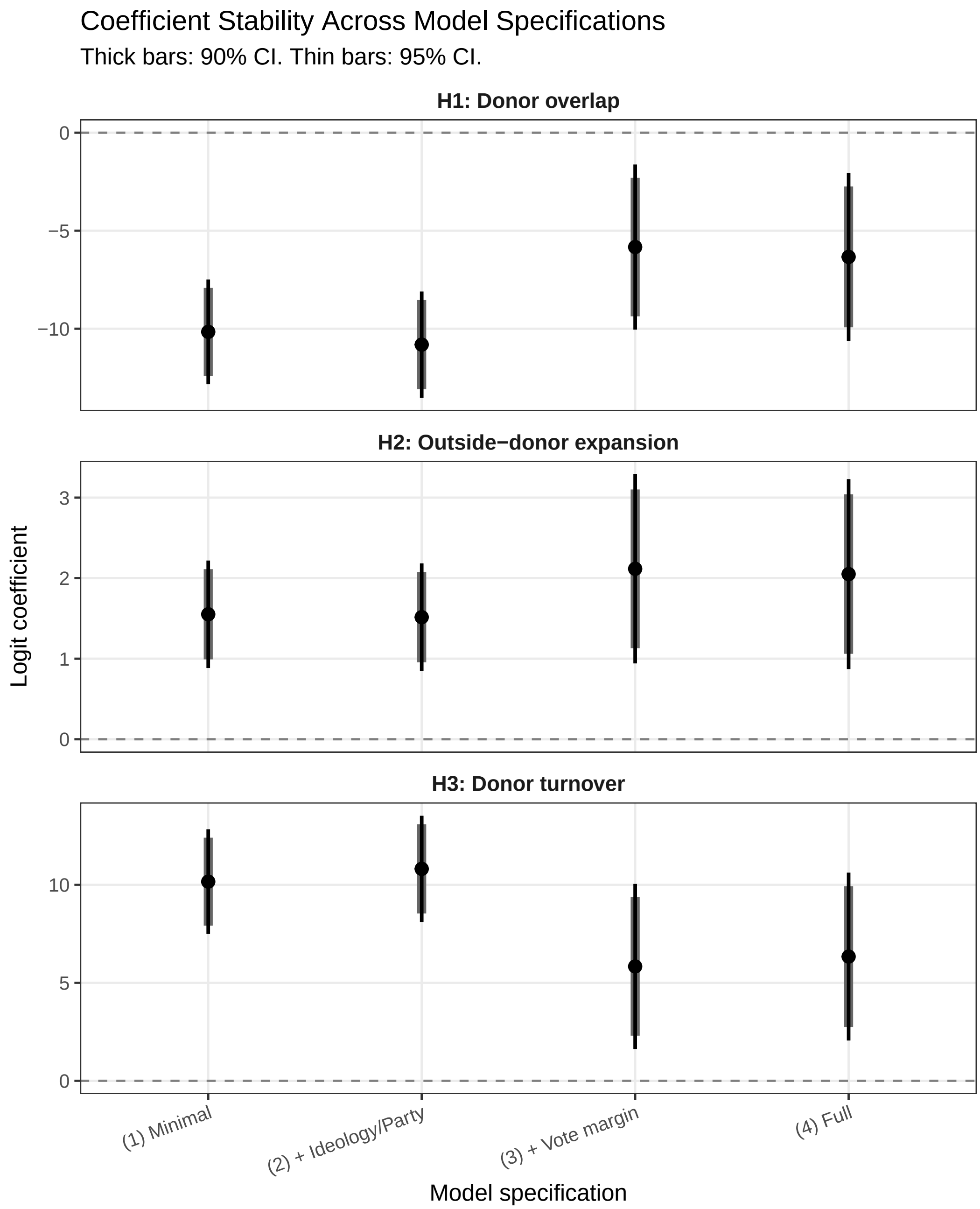

Figure 14: Coefficient Stability Across Model Specifications (H1–H3). Each panel shows the main independent variable coefficient and confidence intervals across four progressively richer control specifications. Thick bars denote 90% confidence intervals; thin bars denote 95% confidence intervals. Era and party fixed effects included in all specifications. See Table 3, Table 4, and Table 5 for the corresponding tabular results.

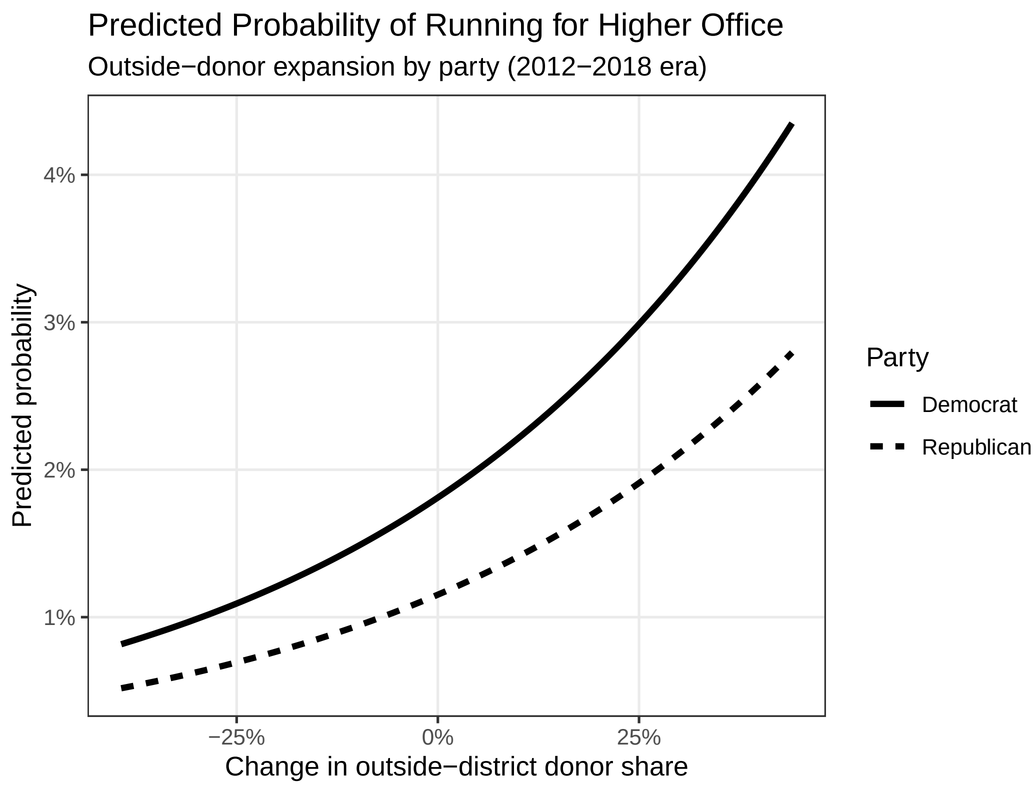

Figure 15: Predicted Probability of Running for Higher Office by Outside-Donor Expansion and Party (H2). Predictions generated from Model 2 (Table 2) holding all covariates at their observed medians. Era set to 2012-2018. Lines show predictions for Democrats and Republicans separately.